

A long-term review

With Digit's 25th Anniversary coming into view, I was dumbstruck with figuring out what to write. While I've been around for more than half of this ridiculous journey, this was one of those moments when writer's block really did its magic on me. So the easiest thing to do is to simply start writing. Peering through the thousands of articles written, it seems most of my time with Digit was spent writing reviews. It makes sense for this piece to end up being a review of sorts. Honestly speaking, I don't know if I'm reviewing Digit over the past 25 years or if I'm reviewing the Indian technological landscape over the past two decades and change.

If the last 25 years of Indian consumer technology were a product, it would be a nightmare to review. The design has changed too many times, the unprompted software updates, the ecosystem grew faster than the manual, and the user base discovered many unpredictable use cases. In fact, the user base have leapfrogged over technology adoption milestones and forced companies to evolve their product specifically for the Indian market. After all, the Indian consumer wants the best and will pay the least. Back when Digit started, we were still in the age of beige desktops, CRT monitors, dial-up modems and pirated software CDs. Faster internet was slowly creeping into the metros and laptops making their way around the corner, and we received what can be described as the biggest technology update with the smartphone. I don't mean to call iPhones and Androids the early smartphones. I'm talking of the Symbian devices. Nokia was still king and everyone had one. We were being looked upon as the Digital Natives by Generation X.

From a design perspective, the early versions of most products can be best described as bulky, noisy and slightly intimidating. Digit's pages were rife with massive comparison test features, in-depth articles that sometimes took nearly a month to research and write, and supplements out the wazoo. This was a time when people still largely read print magazines. We were part of the few who



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Mithun Mohandas
Managing Editor



Let me know your thoughts on this column at:
@mithun_mohandas | mithun@digit.in

had access to near limitless internet plans and practically limitless troves of knowledge. Our job, which continues to this day, was to bring the most important bits to you. In all our homes, Technology had a designated corner. The family PC sat under a cloth cover. The monitor took up half the desk. Speakers had wires. Printers had moods. The internet made sounds. Hardware kept shrinking while its importance kept expanding. The desktop became a laptop, and slowly the laptop's features moved into the phone. The camera, music player, map, torch, wallet, remote control, newspaper, television and bank branch collapsed into a glass rectangle.

There was a time when performance used to be a measure of patience. You waited for Windows to boot, for web pages to load, for songs to buffer, videos took forever, games had to be installed by swapping out one disc after another in sequential order and using the Internet meant that someone at home had to stop using the landline. All of this feels so alien now. A two-second delay feels like failure. Even a budget phone streams video, handles payments, manages navigation, captures 4K clips and runs more apps than a family PC from two decades ago could imagine. Processors have got so fast that people don't even realise if they're getting anything new at all. We are now in age of plenty and the art of optimising no longer exists. The average Digit reader probably doesn't read much today. You're mostly watching our videos and liking our posts.

After 25 years of testing, Indian consumer tech hasn't emerged as the perfect product. It has crashed, overheated, overpromised, misled, locked users in and demanded upgrades before the previous one felt old. But it has also collapsed distance, democratised access, changed how India pays, learns, works, shops, plays, creates and remembers. It turned the ordinary Indian consumer into one of the sharpest value critics in the world. We'd like to think that Digit has played a similar role in the lives of our readers. Rating this is difficult. Calling it transformative is not. **d**